

MUSIC REVIEW

Fusion
Across
OceansDEBASHISH
BHATTACHARYA

MANEESH AGNIHOTRI

It is a rare honour for an Indian to be nominated for the Grammy. Guitar maestro Debashish Bhattacharya, 46, and Hindustani vocalist Lakshmi Shankar, 86, are among the lucky few in the Best Traditional World Music Album category. While Bhattacharya has been nominated for his album *Calcutta Chronicles: Indian Slide-Guitar Odyssey* (Riverboat Records), Shankar has made an impression with his *Dancing in the Light* (World Village).

"It is as if I have reached the World Cup football semi-final. This honour is for my instrument to which I have devoted more than 40 years," says Bhattacharya. *Calcutta Chronicles* captures Bhattacharya's experience as he grew up in Kolkata attending concerts of Pandit Ravi Shankar, Ustad Ali Akbar Khan and others. "Those were the memories I wanted to download through my guitar," he says.

Taking to the guitar in a country like India hasn't been easy because he had to deal with stereotype—of Western instruments not merging well with Indian culture. But a

designer-artist, he improvised and came up with 19 slide guitars. He created a trinity of slide guitars, giving them names like Chatur-angui, Gandharvi and Anandi. "They are my ammunition to fight ignorance," he says. The slide guitar was introduced in India in 1929 by Tau Moe of Hawaii. The cross-cultural exchange eventually gave birth to a new sound in Hindustani classic instrumental music.

The foremost exponent of this genre was Pandit Brij Bhushan Kabra under whose guidance Bhattacharya grew. Bhattacharya has performed with tabla maestro Ustad Zakir Hussain and John McLaughlin among others. "I am happy that I am part of the history of growth of the Indian guitar," he says, adding that artistes like him are not mere musicians but peace-makers. The guitar to him is a symbol of youth and energy.

by S. Sahaya Ranjit

CALCUTTA CHRONICLES:
INDIAN SLIDE-GUITAR
ODYSSEY
INDIABEAT

ART EXHIBITION

Impression in Time



Recent works by Navin Thomas, Sudarshan Shetty and Zakkir Hussain at Gallery SKE, Bangalore, present a myriad of images representing the time we live in. With his inkjet prints on aluminum sheets, Thomas speaks of the birth of colour TV. Hussain's images like stretchers from the hospital and Shetty's photographic series feature images of a Beetle car in a time frame extending the performance art in the art of display. On display till January 10.

by Nirmala Ravindran

ART EXHIBITION

Back to the Past



Gallery Espace presents *Allure*, an art exhibition of acrylic and ink on paper by Brooklyn-based artist, Rina Banerjee. The way she assembles colonial objects makes history in art a unique experience. "My sculptures, installations, videos and drawings are inspired by a wide range of mundane objects and home crafts," says Banerjee. On till January 13 in Delhi.